

UNDP BiH response to 2014 floods

After Action Review

Summary

In May 2014, massive floods hit the Balkans and caused extensive damage in several countries. UNDP BiH Country Office rapidly designed and implemented immediate response and early recovery interventions, followed by comprehensive recovery and resilience-building programmes. The organization mobilized ample resources: 1.2 million USD in CERF grants, and more than 80 million USD for recovery and resilience. UNDP response included coordination and information management, debris management and mine action; recovery activities, based on the Recovery Needs Assessment, were organized in two main programmes: the EU Floods Recovery Programme and the UN Floods Recovery Programme. They focused on emergency housing rehabilitation, the rehabilitation and restoration of public services and facilities, and of communal infrastructure, and livelihoods support. The CO adopted a consistent approach and transition between response, early recovery and recovery, and targeted the most vulnerable groups affected by the crisis.

UNDP Crisis Response Unit and the CO conducted in 2016 an After Action Review to learn from the experience, highlighting key successes and enabling factors, as well as gaps and challenges encountered. The AAR is aimed at improving UNDP's future performance; it informs the revision of the Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response and the development of the Crisis Response Packages.

Successes of the response and enabling factors

Leadership - Experienced senior management demonstrated leadership in the crisis response and recovery, by initiating preparedness and early response actions, using corporate tools available, rapidly taking critical decisions, anticipating potential difficulties and taking required measures to counter their impact. It supported national staff in running the response and endorsed unusual but innovative approaches that proved to be successful.

Early action - The CO, under the guidance of the Resident Coordinator, was reactive and fast in taking early actions that facilitated the response. Rapidity and decisiveness allowed quick resolution of emerging issues or avoided them altogether, expediting response and recovery in multiple ways.

Knowledge and use of corporate support and corporate tools for crisis response - Both management and staff, including former SURGE deployees, knew and activated crisis response procedures, and were aware of how to implement them effectively.

CO capacity and field presence - The CO had a capable, experienced team, including several staff members as SURGE Advisors (both in Programme and Operations). The CO had a solid network and field presence, expanded by the opening of three more field offices. The field presence was a key element of UNDP's performance and constituted a distinct advantage for the organization.

National response - The national response (as opposed to an international humanitarian surge) was clearly a strength. Key strategic decisions were taken immediately and on the ground, the committed CO team leveraged its knowledge of the context and language, the networks and relations established in pre-floods activities, managed activities through all phases, transitioning from crisis response and early recovery to recovery and back to normal programmes, DRR and resilience-building.

Nature of programmes and UNDP's mandate - Assessed needs matched UNDP's expertise in areas like debris removal, cash for work, emergency employment, livelihoods restoration. This was different from usual emergency responses, where immediate needs are often food, WASH, health, shelter and so on. The experience and technical knowledge of the main response and recovery sectors facilitated quality and creative programme design and implementation. UNDP's recovery mandate, and previous work in governance, local development, livelihoods and DRR, allowed seamless phasing-in and phasing-out of programmatic interventions.

Relation with authorities at national and local level - UNDP had a positive relation with government counterparts, at state and entity level, despite the complex governance structure of the country. Relations were also very solid with

local authorities and especially municipalities thanks to pre-existing programmes. This facilitated needs assessments and implementation of activities.

Relations with donors and resource mobilization - The positive and longstanding relation with donors allowed rapid consultations for repurposing of funds, which were critical for the initial response, together with internal resources and CERF funds; donors trusted UNDP's recommendations for the immediate response, and for recovery later on. The successful mobilization of humanitarian resources, made possible by the access to seed funds to kick-start the response, contributed in turn to the extremely successful mobilization of recovery funds.

Critical information and coordination role played by UNDP - The leadership role assumed by UNDP in coordination and information management gave visibility to its work and to the quality of its response. Its effectiveness positioned UNDP strategically at the centre of the response, reinforced the donors' confidence in the organisation and was ultimately instrumental in securing the large funding received for recovery programmes.

Opportunities created by the context - Some favourable circumstances have partially contributed to the CO achievements. These include the limited national capacities to coordinate and implement the response, which provided the space for UNDP to take a leading role; the limited presence of traditional humanitarian actors, reducing the competition for funds; the status of BiH as an EU pre-accession country, which influenced the political opportunity of a large external intervention, favouring instead a BiH-based response.

Challenges and gaps

Gender equality programming - The integration of gender equality in the response and recovery activities could have been stronger: it was insufficient or insufficiently integrated in needs assessments, including in the RNA; UNDP did not conduct a proper gender analysis prior to programme design, and the recovery programmes did not present a comprehensive gender equality approach. The organization recognized the gap and conducted a "lessons learned" exercise on the integration of gender equality in programming, identifying specific areas for improvement.

CO preparedness - The CO had not *intentionally* prepared to respond or taken substantial preparedness measures; it was well positioned to implement a successful response, thanks to the multiple enabling factors earlier identified; however there was not a structural commitment to preparedness.

Real-time evaluation - During the response, the CO did not conduct real-time assessments/evaluations on the quality of the response, losing the chance of identifying and correcting potential overlooks and pitfalls.

UNDP internal systems - The nature of the programme in BiH required expensive procurement, which often surpassed the CO authority even with the increased threshold of the Fast Track Procedures. The process was burdensome and some simplification for emergency contexts would be helpful.

RNA - The quality of the RNA was limited by multiple factors, including the short timeframe available, the strong political pressures that led to negotiations on the estimations of damages and losses, the limited integration of a gender equality approach.

Limited national capacities - National authorities were not able to manage efficiently the coordination of the response; there had been limited previous work with the state on preparedness and disaster risk management. Initially a challenge, this became an opportunity for UNDP to take a leading role.

Local ownership - Local ownership of the response in some communities was limited, when political consideration overshadowed the need to assist the population. The CO reports that in some areas accountability to affected populations by local authorities remained elusive, despite the significant efforts deployed by the organization.

Limited capacity of UN agencies - Some UN agencies had limited capacity to respond; this, however, became an opportunity for UNDP, as it permitted a broader role for the organization and reduced the competition for humanitarian funds.

Moving forward

UNDP has identified areas for improvement at country level and globally as an organization, as a result of the BiH experience. The organization will focus on strengthening leadership and management capacity for crisis response, as well as national capacities of staff within COs. A stronger investment on CO preparedness will accompany the review of the SOPs and the finalization of standard Crisis Response Packages, aimed at increasing UNDP's preparedness and capacity to respond. The organization will also focus on improving its performance on assessments, particularly in the case of PDNAs; on programmes, stressing gender equality in crisis and recovery programming; and on operations.